Lesson 14: Sentence Essentials 2: Compound and Complex Sentences, Sentence Variety

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 7 Sentence Essentials: V. Sentence structure #2: Compound Sentences; VI. Sentence Structure #3: Complex Sentences; VII. Sentence Variety; VIII. Unit Review Practice.

In this lesson

This lesson continues Lesson 13, where you learned that a simple sentence is one independent clause. Now you join clauses to make compound sentences (with FANBOYS or adverbial conjunctions) and complex sentences (with subordinating conjunctions), each with its own punctuation. You also learn to mix the three sentence types, so that your academic paragraphs are clear and not choppy.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Write compound sentences with a comma + FANBOYS, and with a semicolon + adverbial conjunction + comma.
- Write complex sentences with subordinating conjunctions, with a comma only when the dependent clause comes first.
- Identify simple, compound and complex sentences, and correct comma mistakes in a paragraph.
- Revise a paragraph for a better balance of sentence types.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
independent clause	a "subject + verb" group with a complete idea; it can stand alone as a simple sentence (Lesson 13)	Writing is challenging.
compound sentence	two independent clauses joined by a coordinating or an adverbial conjunction	Writing is challenging, so I am studying very hard.
FANBOYS (coordinating conjunctions)	for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so	We have a writing class, and we like it.
adverbial conjunction (transition)	a more formal connector, such as however, therefore, in addition	They had studied very hard; therefore, they passed the test with an A.
complex sentence	one independent clause + one dependent clause	When I got home, my sister was watching TV.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
dependent clause	subordinating conjunction + subject + verb; it cannot stand alone	because I wanted to finish my homework
subordinating conjunction	a word that starts a dependent clause, such as when, because, although, if	If the parents want to, they can observe their children.
choppy (adj)	broken, not connected	Too many simple sentences will make your writing sound choppy.
accomplished (adj)	successful in doing something	Maria and Sung are very busy; however, they feel accomplished.
resemble (v)	is similar to	A compound sentence resembles a couple living together.
overuse (v)	use too many times	It is common to overuse words like "and", "because".
accordingly (adv)	as a result, therefore	Change the sentence structure and punctuation accordingly.
comparable (adj)	similar	Ideally, the number of each should be comparable.

Rules and explanations

The book compares a **compound** sentence to a married couple: two independent people connected by love (the conjunction). A **complex** sentence is like a parent with a baby: the dependent clause cannot live by itself.

Compound sentences with FANBOYS

Pattern: independent clause + **comma** + FANBOYS + independent clause.

Conjunction	Meaning	Example
for	a reason	We have taken three writing classes, for writing is a very important skill.
and	adds a point	We have a writing class, and we like it.
nor	adds a negative point	We do not have a test this week, nor are we going to have one next week.
but	an opposite point	I try to be on time for my writing class, but it's hard to get up in the morning.
or	a choice	Next semester, I may take another writing class, or I may choose a grammar class.
yet	an opposite point (stronger)	One of my classmates has failed most tests, yet he does not care.

Conjunction	Meaning	Example
so	a result	Writing is challenging, so I am studying very hard.

- After **nor**, the helping verb (do, be, have, can ...) comes before the subject; do not add another "no" or "not": "I do not like hot dogs, nor do I like hamburgers."
- A sentence is compound only when there is a full clause on each side of the conjunction: "We are taking this writing course for three reasons." (simple) / "We are taking this writing course, for writing is important." (compound)

Compound sentences with adverbial conjunctions

Meaning	Adverbial conjunctions (transitions)
to add a point	also, besides, furthermore, in addition, moreover
to show a result	as a result, consequently, therefore, thus
to show an opposite point	however, nevertheless
to give an example	for example, for instance

- Pattern: independent clause + **semicolon** + adverbial conjunction + **comma** + independent clause: "I am taking two courses at Harper College; in addition, I have a full-time job."
- Or write two simple sentences: a period, then the conjunction with a capital letter: "They had studied very hard. Therefore, they passed the test with an A." This is common when the sentences are long.
- There is always a comma after the adverbial conjunction.

Complex sentences

Meaning	Subordinating conjunctions
time	as soon as, before, after, since, until, when, while
contrast	although, though, even though
reason	as, because, since
condition	if, unless

- Dependent clause first: put a **comma** after it. "Although English is a difficult language, I am trying my best to learn it."
- Independent clause first: **no comma**. "I am trying my best to learn English although it is a difficult language."

Sentence variety

- Too many simple sentences sound choppy; too many compound and complex sentences can be hard to read. Use a balanced mix.

- Do not overuse the same conjunctions: replace "and" with "in addition" or "because" with "since", and change the punctuation accordingly.
- Count your simple, compound and complex sentences; the numbers should be comparable. In the lesson material, the first "Fast Track Programs" paragraph has 12 simple, 1 compound and 1 complex sentence; the improved version has 4, 3 and 3.

Quick punctuation check (IC = independent clause, DC = dependent clause): IC, FANBOYS IC. / IC; however, IC. / IC. However, IC. / DC, IC. / IC DC.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Do not use "although" and "but" in the same sentence: "Although English is a difficult language, I am trying my best to learn it", not "Although English is a difficult language, but I am ...".
> - Arabic writing often links many clauses with "and". In English, vary the connections (but, so, however, because, when) and their punctuation.

Practice

1. Pretest, items 5-10. (Items 1-4 were in Lesson 13.) Is each sentence simple, compound or complex?

- (5) The children can attend full or half day programs.
- (6) There are different interest centers, and the children can choose their activities.
- (7) The activities include areas in language, math, science, social studies, physical and emotional development.
- (8) It has a good learning environment, so the children and parents love it.
- (9) If the parents want to, they can observe their children through a one-way mirror.
- (10) This school has received awards from the state government; therefore, it has an excellent reputation.

2. Exercise 5. Use the given adverbial conjunction to combine the simple sentences into a compound sentence. Then use the same conjunction to write two simple sentences.

Example: Studying a second language is difficult. It is very useful in finding a job. (however) → Studying a second language is difficult; however, it is very useful in finding a job. / ... difficult. However, it is ...

1. Almost all the jobs require good speaking skills. They need good writing skills. (moreover)
2. Many people from other countries have good technical skills. They need time to perfect their communication skills. (however)
3. They are highly motivated to learn. They work very hard. (furthermore)
4. They try different ways to improve. Some of them take classes. (for instance)
5. They are able to do well at work. Hard work pays off. (therefore)

3. Exercise 6. Join the two simple sentences into a complex sentence with the subordinating conjunction given. Use commas where necessary.

Example: At 9 am yesterday, Jose was listening to the radio. He was driving to Harper. (while) → At 9 am yesterday, Jose was listening to the radio while he was driving to Harper.

1. Priti has decided to travel to Aruba during the semester break. She has always been interested in its culture. (because)
2. This is Amy's first year in the U.S. She speaks English fluently. (although)
3. Lilly did not wake up early on time yesterday. She missed the first part of the class. (as)
4. Yuri started an ESL class. He arrived in this city. (as soon as)
5. Max had never used a computer. He liked his first online class. (even though)
6. Misako ran into her former classmate. She was looking for her new textbook in the bookstore. (while)
7. At the end of last semester, Kang Sun returned to Korea to visit her family. She had saved enough money for a plane ticket. (after)
8. The next semester starts two months later. Every student needs to decide what classes to take. (before)

4. Exercise 12. Read "My Uncle and I" in the lesson material. There are five more mistakes in the use of commas (not including the example: "First he" → "First, he"). Find them and correct them.

More items: lesson material, Exercises 4, 8 and 9 (sentence types), 10 (combining sentences) and 11 (choosing conjunctions). Your tutor can check them.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me ten sentences about American history: some simple, some compound and some complex. I will name each type and explain how I know."
- "Give me two simple sentences at a time. I will join them with a conjunction that you choose. Check my punctuation."
- "Check my sentences for Exercise 13 in the lesson material: [paste]."
- "Test me on the punctuation of 'but' and 'however' with five sentences."

Read aloud

The mark | shows a short pause at a comma or semicolon. Capitals show word stress.

1. Writing is challenging, | so I am studying very hard.
2. We do not have a test this week, | nor are we going to have one next week.
3. Maria and Sung are very busy; | however, | they feel ac·COM·plished.
4. Although English is a difficult language, | I am trying my best to learn it.
5. Ideally, | the number of each should be COM·pa·ra·ble.

Writing task

Revise the paragraph of simple sentences that you wrote in Lesson 13, or write a new paragraph of 10 to 12 sentences on a weekly prompt from Appendix A (Lesson 1) (the book's Exercise 7 and NSNT Practice).

- Combine some simple sentences, so that the numbers of simple, compound and complex sentences are comparable (for example, 4, 3 and 3). Write the numbers under your paragraph.
- Use at least two FANBOYS, two adverbial conjunctions and two subordinating conjunctions, all different.

Self-editing checklist:

- A comma comes before FANBOYS when it joins two clauses, but not when "and" joins two words.
- After "nor", the helping verb comes before the subject.
- Adverbial conjunctions have a semicolon before and a comma after, or a period before, a capital letter and a comma after.
- A dependent clause at the beginning has a comma after it; at the end, no comma.
- Every dependent clause is attached to an independent clause.
- "Although" and "but" are not in the same sentence.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

1. Pretest (book): 5 simple; 6 compound; 7 simple; 8 compound; 9 complex; 10 compound.

2. Exercise 5. The book gives no key. The compound sentence is given; for the two simple sentences, change "; moreover," to ". Moreover," and so on.

1. Almost all the jobs require good speaking skills; moreover, they need good writing skills.
2. Many people from other countries have good technical skills; however, they need time to perfect their communication skills.
3. They are highly motivated to learn; furthermore, they work very hard.
4. They try different ways to improve; for instance, some of them take classes.
5. They are able to do well at work; therefore, hard work pays off. (The reverse order is also correct: "Hard work pays off; therefore, they are able to do well at work.")

3. Exercise 6. The book gives no key. In every item, the other order is also correct: a dependent clause first takes a comma; a dependent clause second takes no comma. Put the name in the first clause and "he" or "she" in the second.

1. Priti has decided to travel to Aruba during the semester break because she has always been interested in its culture. (Or: Because Priti has always been interested in Aruba's culture, she has decided to travel there during the semester break.)
2. Although this is Amy's first year in the U.S., she speaks English fluently.
3. As Lilly did not wake up early on time yesterday, she missed the first part of the class.
4. Yuri started an ESL class as soon as he arrived in this city. (Or: As soon as Yuri arrived in this city, he started an ESL class.)
5. Even though Max had never used a computer, he liked his first online class.
6. Misako ran into her former classmate while she was looking for her new textbook in the bookstore.
7. At the end of last semester, Kang Sun returned to Korea to visit her family after she had saved enough money for a plane ticket.
8. Before the next semester starts two months later, every student needs to decide what classes to take.

4. Exercise 12. The book gives no key.

1. "a much cleaner, and safer environment" → "a much cleaner and safer environment" (no comma when "and" joins only two adjectives).
2. "Second his accomplishments" → "Second, his accomplishments" (comma after a transition at the start of a sentence).
3. "I started a new life, as soon as I arrived here." → "I started a new life as soon as I arrived here." (independent clause first: no comma)
4. "...in a finance field so I have been taking..." → "...in a finance field, so I have been taking..." (comma before FANBOYS between two clauses)

5. "My uncle always says, that a good future needs good health." → "My uncle always says that a good future needs good health." (no comma before "that")

My notes